but the Indian occupation continued. The fidayeen were told they could help to liberate Indian-administered Kashmir by bleeding India. Because the country's financial strength was in Mumbai, which was also a tourist destination, it was imperative to strike targets that would make India a less attractive venue for businesses and tourists alike.[110] In this regard, Lashkar's calculus was no different than if it had adhered to the original, and more modest, plan to strike the Taj hotel. The attacks were intended to punish and coerce India, a long-standing Lashkar objective. Their spectacular nature and the inclusion of foreign targets served an additional purpose. The group had been playing a double game since the beginning of the decade: India-centric proxy on the one hand, participant in the global jihad against America and its allies on other. Mumbai was intended to reconcile the two and to enhance Lashkar's credibility in the eyes of the jihadi community in Pakistan.

A number of interlocutors remarked that the attacks came as a surprise. Not only because the group had never before launched such a bold operation or deliberately targeted Westerners and Jews in India, but also because in recent years it had kept a low profile to the point of being overshadowed by other jihadi groups in Pakistan. Headley affirmed this assessment in his testimony, in which he described how the aggression and commitment of those fighting against the Crusader forces in Afghanistan (and in certain cases against Pakistan as well) influenced some committed fighters to leave Kashmir-centric groups. In his words, this 'compelled the LeT to consider a spectacular terrorist strike in India.' He also suggested that Lashkar's ISI handlers approved the Mumbai attacks as a result of their awareness that the group needed to show results in order for the leadership to retain control over elements within the organization.[111] Once the determination was made to stage a terrorist spectacular, the process took over. Operational necessity was a major factor in shifting to a martyrdom attack, a decision that contributed to Mumbai's duration and hence to its sensational nature. Another consequence of dropping the egress option was the late inclusion of the railway terminus, where one third of the fatalities occurred. It was also the scene of the most indiscriminate killing, in contrast to the hotels where the fidayeen took some steps to avoid murdering Muslims. Thus, two of the most notable aspects of the attacks—their duration and the high body count—were attributable to the operational demands of staging a ten-person, multi-target assault. This does not detract